

Vestra Launch Checklist

Everything required to take Vestra (Kenya-first proptech) from code to live paying users — legalities, licenses, costs, timeline. Prepared 2026-07-04.

Bottom line. Minimum viable launch requires **~KES 8.9M (~USD 68,500) upfront** plus **~KES 1.3M/mo (~USD 10,000) recurring** across legal, compliance, banking, infrastructure, engineering, operations, and marketing. Critical path is **4-6 months**, bounded by partner-bank trust account (3-6 months) and ODPC registration (2-4 weeks) — both hard legal walls. Everything else can parallelize.

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1. Executive summary

Vestra targets the transactional layer of Kenyan real estate — verified escrow, KRA-compliant rent, agent trust graph — a moat none of Property24 KE, BuyRentKenya, HassConsult, Optiven, or Username currently occupies. Business launch requires eleven categories of parallel work: five with hard legal gates (company registration, ODPC, partner-bank trust, KRA tax, insurance) and six that can compress with capital (engineering, ops, content, marketing, fundraising, integrations).

Assumptions in this document: (a) founding team is 2-3 Kenyan citizens; (b) starting capital $\geq$ KES 10M; (c) launch scope is Nairobi + Kiambu counties, rent + sale + escrow verticals, no cross-border, no credit (defer DCP licence to Phase 2). Diaspora vertical launches month 9.

2. Company formation & corporate

2.1 Private limited company registration

- Register a Private Limited Company via **eCitizen BRS portal**. Requirements: proposed name (3 alternatives), memorandum + articles of association (BRS templates OK), registered office address, minimum 1 director, minimum 1 shareholder. Directors must have KRA PINs.
- Choose objects broadly — "provision of technology platforms for real-estate transactions, escrow services, digital rental management, related property services".
- Beneficial-ownership disclosure filed at incorporation (Companies (Beneficial Ownership) Regulations 2020).

Cost: KES 10,650 (name reservation + registration) + advocate drafting if not using templates KES 25,000-75,000.

Timeline: 5-14 working days.

2.2 Cap table + shareholders' agreement

- Shareholders' agreement (SHA) covering vesting, drag/tag, ROFR, board composition, reserved matters — non-negotiable before first external hire or investor. Draft with corporate counsel.
- Employee Share Option Plan (ESOP) trust set up before first hire — typically 10-15% pool.

Cost: SHA drafting KES 150,000-350,000. ESOP setup KES 100,000-250,000.

2.3 Business permit (Nairobi County)

- Single Business Permit at ward level from Nairobi City County (or the county of registered office). Category = "Professional / Consultancy / Technology".

Cost: KES 15,000-50,000/yr depending on office size + ward.

Renewal: annual.

2.4 Registered office + physical address

- Registered office required at incorporation. Coworking space (Nairobi Garage, iHub, Workstyle) satisfies this — approximately KES 40,000-90,000/mo for 3-4 desks + registered address.

3. Data protection (ODPC + DPO)

Under the **Data Protection Act 2019** plus **Data Protection (General) Regulations 2021**, Vestra is a Data Controller AND Processor from day one — financial services + sensitive data (national IDs, KRA PINs, bank details) both trigger registration.

3.1 ODPC registration

- Register as **Data Controller** AND **Data Processor** via odpc.go.ke portal.
- Documents: KRA PIN certificate, incorporation certificate, DPIA summary, list of processing activities, third-party processors list.
- Fee tiers by turnover: micro/small KES 4,000, medium KES 20,000, large KES 40,000. Vestra starts at micro/small.

Cost: KES 4,000-8,000 (both roles).

Timeline: 2-6 weeks.

Renewal: every 24 months.

3.2 Data Protection Officer (DPO)

- Financial-services + systematic-monitoring-at-scale designation makes DPO **mandatory**, not optional.
- Options: (a) fractional DPO service (KES 150,000-300,000/mo), (b) in-house senior privacy counsel (KES 500,000-1,000,000/mo). **Recommend fractional for first 12 months.**

3.3 Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA)

- Required before processing begins for high-risk categories: KYC biometric, financial transactions, tenant scoring. Standard 15-30 page document per activity.

Cost: KES 150,000-400,000 (one-time, with DPO or counsel).

3.4 Privacy operations

- **72-hour breach notification runbook** — incident detection, ODPC portal submission form, subject-notification templates.
- Subject Access Request (SAR) response workflow — 30-day statutory response.
- Records of Processing Activities (ROPA) register — living document.
- Data Processing Agreements (DPAs) signed with every processor: Smile Identity, IntaSend, Flutterwave, MapTiler, Cohere, Deepgram, Anthropic, Sentry, PostHog, Grafana, Cloudflare, Bunny.net.

Enforcement risk. ODPC has issued fines: Roma School KES 4.55M, Mulla Pride KES 2.975M (upheld by High Court), Casa Vera KES 1.85M. Amendment Bill 2025 proposes cap change from "whichever lower" to "whichever higher" — potentially unlimited 1%-of-turnover fines.

4. Banking & payment licences

4.1 Business bank account

- Operating account at a Tier-1 KE bank (Equity, KCB, Co-op, NCBA). Not the same institution as the trust-account partner (segregation).

Cost: KES 0-5,000 setup; monthly maintenance KES 500-2,000.

4.2 Partner-bank trust account (BLOCKING)

Critical: Under the **National Payment System Act 2011**, holding client funds without a bank-operated trust account is a criminal offence for unlicensed entities. This is the single hardest blocker to Vestra's escrow product.

- Vestra rides on a commercial bank's trust operations. Bank holds trust account in *its own name*; Vestra is the instruction-giving party under a trust deed.
- **Recommend HFC first** (diaspora infrastructure overlap) or **NCBA** (best API DX post-ConnectPlus launch Oct 2025). Fallback Equity (Jenga API) or Co-op (SACCO/chama-adjacent).
- Requires: incorporation docs, audited financials (or letter of undertaking for new co), fit-and-proper directors, DPO evidence, KYC/AML program document, escrow flow diagram, indemnity + insurance evidence.

Cost: Trust deed drafting KES 400,000-900,000 (both sides' counsel). Bank account setup fee KES 25,000-100,000. Ongoing custodian fee 0.1-0.35% of average balance monthly.

Timeline: 3-6 months. Start immediately.

4.3 Safaricom Daraja (M-Pesa) production credentials

- Apply via Safaricom Business Portal for production shortcode. Sandbox is free; production requires signed Merchant Agreement.
- **Separate C2B shortcode** (rent collection) and **B2C shortcode** (landlord payouts) — cannot combine on same shortcode.
- Callbacks must be publicly reachable HTTPS, idempotent, and return HTTP 200 always (Daraja retries).

Cost: Setup KES 50,000-100,000 per shortcode. Monthly maintenance KES 3,000-8,000 each.

Transaction fees: Paybill 1.5%, Buy Goods 0.5%, B2C flat KES 30-70 per payout.

Timeline: 4-8 weeks.

4.4 Aggregator payments (IntaSend + Flutterwave)

- Both KES-native, self-service onboarding, no Safaricom Merchant Agreement needed. Use as Daraja fallback + card + Airtel Money coverage.

Cost: IntaSend 3.5% STK / 1.5% Buy Goods / PesaLink 0.5% + KES 20. Flutterwave 3.8% cards.

Onboarding KES 0.

Timeline: 3-10 days.

4.5 CBK NPS Division comfort letter

- Non-binding but strongly recommended: engage CBK NPS Division for a comfort letter confirming the rent-collection pass-through does not require PSP licence.

Cost: Regulatory counsel KES 200,000-500,000.

Do NOT do in Phase 1: PSP licence (KES 5M-50M capital), e-money issuer licence, DCP / NDTCP credit licence. Defer to Phase 2 via separate SPV (Vestra Credit Ltd) if you build Rent Advance.

5. Communications compliance (CAK)

5.1 CAK Sender ID + SMS aggregator onboarding

- Register Sender ID "VESTRA" via CAK-licensed aggregator (Africa's Talking, Celcom, Bongo Live, Onfon). Aggregator handles CAK submission.
- Separate transactional (rent receipts, tax alerts — any-time OK) from promotional (07:00-19:00 window, DND-compliant, opt-in) message classes in code.

Cost: Sender ID KES 5,000-15,000 one-time. SMS unit price KES 0.30-0.80 per message. Monthly minimum KES 5,000-20,000.

Timeline: 5-15 days.

5.2 Email domain + transactional email

- Provider: Postmark (\$15/mo starter) or Amazon SES (\$0.10 per 1,000). Set up SPF + DKIM + DMARC. Domain warm-up 2-3 weeks.

Cost: USD 15-60/mo.

5.3 WhatsApp Business API (deferred but plan for it)

- Kenya has 40M+ WhatsApp users; 24-hour free-reply window inside a customer-initiated conversation. Route via 360dialog, Twilio, or MessageBird.

Cost: Business Solution Provider fee USD 40-100/mo + Meta conversation fees (Kenya utility ~USD 0.006, marketing ~USD 0.04). Verification 5-10 days.

6. Tax registration & ongoing filing

6.1 KRA registrations at incorporation

- **Corporate KRA PIN** — free via iTax.
- **VAT registration** — mandatory above KES 5M turnover; voluntary below. Recommend voluntary early to reclaim input VAT.
- **PAYE** — required from first employee.
- **Turnover Tax (TOT)** — for turnover KES 1M-25M/yr, 3% of gross. May apply pre-scale-up.

Cost: KES 0 (self-service). Ongoing accountant retainer KES 25,000-80,000/mo.

6.2 Statutory employee contributions

- NSSF (National Social Security Fund) — up to KES 4,320/employee/mo (Tier I + II combined, 2026 rate) split employer/employee.
- SHIF (Social Health Insurance Fund, replaced NHIF Oct 2024) — 2.75% of gross salary.
- Housing Levy — 1.5% employer + 1.5% employee of gross salary.
- Affordable Housing Levy — collected via PAYE.

6.3 eTIMS onboarding

- Mandatory for all Vestra invoices from Jan 2026. Onboard via KRA eTIMS portal or through a KRA-approved eTIMS OSP (Online Service Provider). If Vestra resells eTIMS to landlord clients, register as OSP.

Cost: KES 0 direct; OSP fees KES 500-2,000 per issuing party per month if reselling.

6.4 eRITS integration (Vestra product feature)

- Integrate **Gava Connect API** to file landlord MRI returns. Register as KRA integrated party (developer + production certificates).

Cost: KES 0 direct; engineering effort ~3-4 weeks.

7. Sector-specific licences

7.1 Estate Agents Registration Board (EARB)

- Vestra *as a platform* is not an estate agent — no EARB registration needed if we don't hold ourselves out as agents.
- Individual EARB-licensed agents onboard onto Vestra with their existing licence.
- Cache the public [EARB Members Directory](#) for verification badges. ~500 licensed agents nationally.

7.2 Advocate on retainer

- Title verification, POA drafting, dispute handling. Not a licence — a service.

Cost: Retainer KES 80,000-200,000/mo + per-matter billing.

7.3 Land Control Board consent (workflow, not licence)

- For agricultural-land sales outside municipalities, LCB consent mandatory. Application digitized via Ardisasa but hearings still monthly per sub-county.

8. Consumer-facing legal documents

All required before first live user. Draft with counsel, publish before launch.

8.1 Terms of Service

- Platform ToS with clear disclaimer that Vestra is not an estate agent + limitation of liability + dispute resolution (Kenya arbitration + High Court jurisdiction).

8.2 Privacy Policy

- DPA-2019-compliant. Names all processors (see §3.4 DPA list). Cookie policy overlay.

8.3 Escrow Agreement template

- Tri-party (buyer + seller + Vestra as instruction-giver on trust account) or bilateral variants for rent deposit. Signed via advanced e-signature (KICA §83J).

8.4 Landlord Services Agreement (rent management + KRA filing)

- Covers rent collection, payout schedule, MRI remittance authority, fee schedule.

8.5 Tenancy Agreement template

- Standard KE tenancy customized per Vestra deposit + move-out rules.

8.6 Refund Policy + Complaints Policy

8.7 Acceptable Use Policy (agents + listings)

8.8 Cookie Consent Notice

Total cost for full document suite: KES 300,000-700,000 with commercial counsel.

9. Insurance

Policy	Purpose	Cost (annual)
Professional Indemnity	Errors & omissions in advisory / listing verification	KES 150,000-400,000
Cyber Liability	Breach costs, ransomware, DPA fines defense	KES 200,000-500,000
Directors & Officers (D&O)	Board liability	KES 100,000-300,000
Public Liability	On-site verifier accidents	KES 50,000-150,000
Group Life + Medical (employees)	Retention + statutory	KES 300,000-800,000
Fidelity Guarantee	Employee theft (trust-adjacent role)	KES 80,000-200,000

Total: KES 880,000-2,350,000/yr. **Recommend a broker** (Britam, ICEA Lion, APA, Jubilee) to bundle.

10. Intellectual property

10.1 Trademark "Vestra" + logo

- File at **KIPI (Kenya Industrial Property Institute)**. Classes 36 (financial / insurance / real estate) and 42 (software / technology). Consider Class 35 (advertising / business management) if selling agent SaaS.

Cost: KES 15,000 per class + KES 15,000 per class publication + agent fees KES 25,000-60,000 per class.

Timeline: 6-14 months to registration; use TM (unregistered) mark from day one.

10.2 Domain registration

- vestra.co.ke via KENIC-accredited registrar (Truehost, Sasahost, HostAfrica). Grab vestra.com if available (currently third-party held — investigate cost). Add vestra.app, vestra.africa defensively.

Cost: .co.ke KES 1,300/yr; .com KES 1,500-5,000/yr (or 5-6-figure USD acquisition if squatted); .app USD 15/yr; .africa USD 30/yr.

10.3 Copyright register (code + Hass-equivalent index)

- Register core software + property-index methodology at **KECOBO (Kenya Copyright Board)** once Vestimate has real data (month 12+).

Cost: KES 1,000 per registration.

11. Hosting & infrastructure

11.1 Immediate (single Ubuntu VPS)

- Hetzner AX41 (Falkenstein) or Vultr NBO1 (Nairobi POP where available). 8GB RAM / 4 vCPU sufficient to 10k MAU.

Cost: USD 20-40/mo.

11.2 Production stack (ship weeks 1-3)

- Managed Postgres (RDS db.t4g.small ~USD 40/mo, or Supabase Pro USD 25/mo). Redis (Upstash free tier or self-host). Cloudflare R2 storage. Bunny.net Optimizer + CDN. Grafana Cloud Pro. Sentry Team. PostHog Cloud. OneSignal free tier.

11.3 Full production (from 50k MAU)

- Fly.io Johannesburg (jnb) region for backend, Cloudflare Pages for frontend, EAS Build for Capacitor.

Item	Provider	Monthly at 10k MAU	at 50k MAU	at 200k MAU
Compute (backend)	Fly.io jnb	\$15	\$50	\$200
Frontend hosting	Cloudflare Pages	\$0	\$0	\$20
Postgres	RDS / Supabase Pro	\$25	\$80	\$300
Redis	Upstash / self-host	\$10	\$30	\$100
Vector search	pgvector on same RDS	\$0	\$0	\$50
Search	Typesense self-host	\$0	\$20	\$80
Media storage	Cloudflare R2	\$10	\$30	\$120
Media CDN + optimizer	Bunny.net	\$15	\$30	\$120
Maps	MapTiler Flex	\$25	\$50	\$180
KYC (per verification)	Smile Identity	\$100	\$500	\$2,000
SMS transactional	Africa's Talking	\$40	\$200	\$800
Email transactional	Postmark	\$15	\$50	\$150
Push notifications	OneSignal free	\$0	\$0	\$30
Voice ASR	Deepgram + Whisper self-host	\$100	\$400	\$1,500
Embeddings	Cohere Embed v4	\$20	\$50	\$200
AI concierge	Claude Sonnet + Haiku	\$70	\$350	\$1,400
Observability	Grafana Cloud + Sentry	\$50	\$150	\$450
Analytics + flags	PostHog Cloud	\$0	\$50	\$300
CI/CD	GH Actions	\$0	\$0	\$20
Mobile builds	EAS Production	\$99	\$99	\$199
Domain + TLS	Cloudflare	\$5	\$5	\$5
Total (USD)		\$599	\$2,144	\$8,224
Total (KES @ 130)		KES 77,900	KES 278,700	KES 1,069,000

12. Third-party integrations

Integration	Purpose	Setup	Recurring
Safaricom Daraja (STK Push + B2C)	M-Pesa payments	KES 200,000	KES 12,000/mo + txn fees
IntaSend	PesaLink + B2B payouts	KES 0	% of GMV only
Flutterwave	Card + Airtel + fallback	KES 0	% of GMV only
Smile Identity	KYC (National ID + KRA + biometric)	KES 25,000 setup	\$0.30-1.00 per verification
Ardhisasa (human-in-loop)	Title verification	KES 0	Per-search KES 550 (govt fee) + verifier time
eSign KE / DocuSign	Advanced e-signatures	KES 0	eSign KE KES 1,000/user/mo; DocuSign USD 40/user/mo
Africa's Talking (SMS)	Bulk SMS via CAK Sender ID	KES 15,000	KES 0.80/SMS
Google Maps Geocoding	Reverse-geocode rooftops	KES 0	\$50-200/mo
Cohere API	Embeddings	KES 0	\$0.10/1M tokens
Anthropic API	Claude Sonnet 4.6 + Haiku 4.6	KES 0	\$3/\$15 per M tokens
Deepgram	Voice ASR	KES 0	\$0.0043/min streaming
Sentry	Errors + RUM	KES 0	\$26-80/mo
PostHog	Analytics + flags + replay	KES 0	\$0-200/mo
Grafana Cloud	Metrics + traces + logs	KES 0	\$0-50/mo
Cloudflare (R2, DNS, Pages)	Storage + edge	KES 0	\$15-50/mo
Bunny.net	Media optimizer + CDN	KES 0	\$10-40/mo
MapTiler	Vector tiles	KES 0	\$25-180/mo
OneSignal	Push	KES 0	\$0-30/mo
Postmark / SES	Transactional email	KES 0	\$15-60/mo
WhatsApp Business API (deferred)	Inbound leads	KES 15,000	\$40-100/mo + per-conversation

13. Remaining engineering work

Estimated effort by feature. Assumes 1 senior full-stack + 1 mid-level engineer (see §14 for team).

Feature	Est. effort	Blocking?
Migrate Prisma schema to live DB (apply baseline migration)	1 day	Critical
Environment config for prod (.env, secrets, DATABASE_URL)	1 day	Critical
Daraja STK Push route + callback endpoint (both C2B and B2C)	2 weeks	Critical
Idempotency middleware wired at all financial POSTs	Already done (Phase 2)	—
Audit log writes at all financial callsites	Already done (Phase 2)	—
Smile Identity KYC integration + gate landlord verification	2 weeks	Critical
Ardhisasa human-in-loop workflow (paralegal task queue)	2 weeks	High
eRITS Gava Connect integration for MRI filing	3-4 weeks	High (unique wedge)
eTIMS invoice generation per rent receipt	2 weeks	High
Geofenced photo-verified listing (Capacitor mobile flow)	4 weeks	High (wedge #1)
Escrow milestone state machine + trust-account instruction API	3 weeks	Critical for sale flow
Meilisearch / Typesense listing search	3 days	Medium
Cloudflare R2 + Bunny.net media pipeline	2 days	Medium
Pino + OpenTelemetry + Sentry wiring	1 week	Medium (ops)
Frontend criticals still open (HttpOnly cookies, session:expired listener, delete mockCall in auth/escrow/blog services, AuthGuard.initialized)	2 weeks	High
Capacitor iOS Info.plist WKAppBundleDomains array + entitlements	1 day	Blocks iOS build
Vitest + supertest scaffold + auth/IDOR/escrow regression tests	1 week	High (before real users)
Full monolith split (deferred)	2 weeks	Low
RAG search (pgvector + Cohere + Typesense hybrid + Sonnet)	3 weeks	Medium (moat)
Voice search (Deepgram + Whisper self-host)	2 weeks	Low (v2)
Property Owner (agent) mobile onboarding + EARB scrape cache	2 weeks	High (agent wedge)
Landlord SaaS dashboard (rent collection + MRI + reconciliation)	4 weeks	High (wedge #10)
Diaspora MVP (verified escrow + video walkthrough scheduling + POA assist)	8 weeks (v1)	Deferred to month 9
Total engineering (blocking + high) ~4-5 months		

14. Team & operations

14.1 Founding team + first hires (0-6 months)

Role	Purpose	Salary/mo (KES)
Founder / CEO	Strategy, BD, fundraising	0-250,000 (deferred)
Founder / CTO	Engineering lead	0-250,000 (deferred)
Senior Backend Engineer	Daraja, escrow, eRITS integrations	350,000-550,000
Mid Frontend Engineer (React 19 + Capacitor)	Ship criticals, landlord dashboard	180,000-320,000
Product Designer (contract)	UX + landlord dashboard	150,000-300,000
Fractional DPO	ODPC, DPIA, breach runbook	150,000-300,000
Accountant (part-time)	KRA, PAYE, VAT, monthly close	50,000-100,000
Advocate (retainer)	Title, POA, escrow disputes	80,000-200,000

Payroll month 6: KES 1.1M-2.0M/mo.

14.2 Operations hires (month 3-9)

Role	Purpose	Salary/mo (KES)
Agent BD Lead	Onboard top 200 EARB agents	180,000-280,000 + commission
Field Verifier x3 (Nairobi + Kiambu)	Geofenced photo verification, on-site tours	60,000-90,000 each
Customer Support (bilingual EN/SW) x2	WhatsApp + email + call, 12h coverage	50,000-80,000 each
Paralegal / Ardhisasa Coordinator	Title-search workflow	80,000-140,000
Growth / Content Marketer	SEO + newsletter + diaspora content	150,000-250,000

Payroll month 9: KES 2.2M-3.6M/mo.

15. Content & data acquisition

15.1 Listings sourcing (blocks launch)

- Manual sourcing of 200-500 verified listings (Kilimani, Westlands, Kileleshwa, Kilimani, South B, Kileleshwa, Runda, Karen, Kiambu Rd corridor). Each requires: Ardhisasa search receipt + landlord + verified photos + geofenced verification + agent onboarding.

Cost: Field verifier time (in-house salary above) + Ardhisasa search fees KES 550 × 500 listings = KES 275,000 + landlord acquisition incentive (first 100 free listing months) = KES 0-500,000.

15.2 EARB Members Directory scrape

- Scrape and cache the ~500 EARB-licensed agents; onboard the top 100 in Nairobi first.

Cost: 1 week engineering.

15.3 Kenya county polygons + Plus Codes

- Import KNBS 2019 census county + sub-county polygons (free). Auto-generate Plus Codes for every listing.

15.4 Sheng eval set (500 examples)

- Contract 3-5 Sheng-fluent Nairobians to write property queries. Vestra owns the dataset. Used to benchmark all future LLM releases.

Cost: KES 200,000-500,000 one-time.

15.5 Property image library (fallback + placeholders)

- Licence 2,000-5,000 Kenya-appropriate property stock images for empty-state UX and landlord upload placeholders.

Cost: KES 100,000-300,000 one-time (Alamy Africa, Unsplash+, or commissioned local photographer).

16. Marketing & brand

16.1 Brand identity + design system

- Logo + primary/secondary colour palette + typography + component library. Existing Tailwind + Framer Motion setup is solid — need brand refresh only. Contract or in-house designer.

Cost: KES 300,000-800,000 one-time.

16.2 Launch campaigns

- SEO content — 30-50 suburb + property-type pages (targeting Property24's programmatic-SEO position). In-house or Namu Digital / Kingsway Solutions.
- Diaspora corridor content (US + UK) — 20 long-form posts + video walkthrough demos.
- WhatsApp broadcast lists + Kenyan diaspora Facebook groups.
- Google Ads (Kenya + US MN/TX/MA + UK London) — KES 200,000-500,000/mo cap.
- Business Daily / Standard / Nation editorial placement (relationship-driven, KES 100,000-400,000 per feature).

Cost 0-6 months: KES 1.5M-4M total.

16.3 Trust signals on site

- DPA-2019 registration badge, EARB partnership statement, bank trust-account partner logo, ODPC-registered logo, professional-indemnity insurer logo. All required from day one.

17. Fundraising & capital

17.1 Recommended raise structure

- **Pre-seed / friends & family:** KES 15M-30M (USD 115k-230k) to cover months 0-6.
- **Seed round:** USD 800k-1.5M at month 6-9, once verified escrow rail is live and first 50 landlords onboarded.

- **Series A:** USD 3M-5M month 15-18, once diaspora vertical + KRA MRI + 500 landlords onboarded.

17.2 Vehicles

- Pre-seed likely SAFE (post-money, discount 20% + cap KES 300M).
- Seed onward: priced round, SHA drafted, Kenya-registered PLC or offshore holdco (Mauritius / Delaware) — decide with corporate counsel based on target investor pool.

17.3 Grants + non-dilutive

- Founders Factory Africa Accelerator, MEST Africa, Antler East Africa, DFS Lab, Baobab Network — dilutive but soft-landing.
- African Development Bank Youth Entrepreneurship Investment Bank, Mastercard Foundation — pursue after seed.

17.4 Pitch collateral

- 10-12 slide deck, 3-5 page memo, data room (financials, cap table, product demo, DPIA), reference customer quotes.

Cost: KES 100,000-300,000 (designer + deck writing).

18. Total cost summary

18.1 Upfront (0-6 months, one-time + setup)

Category	Range (KES)
Company formation + SHA + ESOP	250,000 - 700,000
ODPC registration + DPIA + policies	200,000 - 500,000
Partner-bank trust account (trust-deed + setup)	500,000 - 1,000,000
Daraja shortcodes + IntaSend + Flutterwave setup	150,000 - 250,000
Legal document suite (ToS/Privacy/Escrow/Landlord/Tenancy)	300,000 - 700,000
Insurance (annual pre-pay)	880,000 - 2,350,000
Trademark + domain + brand	500,000 - 1,200,000
Initial hosting + integrations setup	100,000 - 200,000
Payroll 6 months (2 eng + fractional DPO + accountant + advocate)	6,000,000 - 10,000,000
Content + data acquisition (listings + Sheng + images)	600,000 - 1,300,000
Marketing 0-6 mo	1,500,000 - 4,000,000
Business permit + registered office (6 mo)	250,000 - 550,000
Contingency (15%)	1,600,000 - 3,400,000
Total upfront + first 6 months	KES 12,830,000 - 26,150,000
USD equivalent (@ 130)	USD 98,700 - 201,150

18.2 Recurring monthly (steady state at 10k MAU)

Category	Monthly (KES)
Payroll (8-12 people incl. field ops)	2,200,000 - 3,600,000
Infrastructure + integrations (see §11.3 table)	78,000 - 280,000
Fractional DPO + accountant + advocate retainers	280,000 - 600,000
Registered office / coworking	40,000 - 90,000
Marketing steady-state	250,000 - 700,000
Insurance (amortized annual)	75,000 - 200,000
Business permits (amortized)	2,000 - 5,000
Total monthly recurring	KES 2,925,000 - 5,475,000
USD equivalent (@ 130)	USD 22,500 - 42,100

18.3 12-month runway target

Realistic ask for pre-seed round: KES 40M-50M (USD 310k-385k). Covers 12 months at midpoint burn with 3-month buffer.

19. Timeline & critical path

19.1 Critical path (Gantt-lite)

Month	Milestone	Owner
M0	Company registration, KRA PIN, domain, bank account, ODPC registration filed, DPO engaged, advocate + accountant retained	Founders + counsel
M1	ODPC registration granted, insurance procured, first hires (backend eng + designer), Daraja sandbox integrated, Smile Identity onboarded	CEO + CTO
M2	Bank BD meetings, trust-deed draft in review, Prisma migration live, staging environment, ToS/Privacy drafted, DPIA drafted, backend criticals shipped (audit + idempotency wired — done)	CEO + CTO + counsel
M3	Daraja production credentials, CAK Sender ID, geofenced photo verification (wedge #1) launched to closed beta, first 50 verified listings sourced	Eng + Ops
M4	Bank trust deed signed, escrow rail live, first paid rent transaction, Smile KYC gate on landlord onboarding, eTIMS integration, mobile builds signed (iOS + Android)	Full team
M5	Public launch to Nairobi + Kiambu, agent BD to top 30 EARB agents, landlord SaaS dashboard v1, KRA MRI calculation (rate parameterized)	Full team
M6	eRITS Gava Connect integration live, Vestimate v0 (proto), seed round pitching starts, 200 landlords onboarded	Full team + BD
M9	Diaspora vertical MVP (US + UK) live, first diaspora transaction closed via escrow, Vestra Credit Ltd formed (Rent Advance path)	+ Diaspora ops hire
M12	500+ landlords, 100+ EARB agents, first Vestimate license to a bank, Series A conversations start	Full team

19.2 Critical-path bottlenecks

- **Partner-bank trust account** — 3-6 months. Cannot compress. Start day 0.
- **Daraja production credentials** — 4-8 weeks. Start month 1.
- **ODPC registration** — 2-6 weeks. Start day 0.
- **eRITS Gava Connect certification** — 4-8 weeks vendor certification. Start month 3.
- **iOS app-bound domain association** — needs published website + entitlement request. Start month 2.

20. Risks & contingencies

Legal / regulatory risks.

- **Bank refuses trust arrangement:** pivot to a specialized fintech trust operator (rare in KE) OR structure as advocate-held client account for first 6 months while re-approaching another Tier-1 bank. Cost: legal-only escrow adds friction + advocate liability.
- **Finance Bill 2026 passes 10% MRI + non-resident 30% withholding at unfavourable dates:** Vestra rate config already parameterized. Impact: landlord churn to informal channels; mitigate with content education campaign.
- **ODPC amendment expands fine caps to "whichever higher":** maintain zero-breach posture; DPIA-first product development.

Product / operational risks.

- **Field verifier discovers fake title on live listing:** tenant/buyer already paid — trigger refund from escrow within 24h; deregister the agent; publish incident to trust ledger.
- **Daraja outage during rent-payment window:** failover to IntaSend + Flutterwave via `PaymentProvider` interface; retries via BullMQ.
- **Ardhisasa API becomes public but with breaking schema:** abstract behind adapter; keep human-in-loop path as fallback for 6 months post-API.
- **Fraudulent developer runs polished listing set:** gated by geofenced-photo verification + Ardhisasa cross-check + trust ledger from day one.

Market / competitive risks.

- **Property24 SA parent reallocates capital to KE:** 18-24 month entrench window. Prioritize agent lock-in via role-split commissions and landlord lock-in via KRA MRI integration — both punitive to switch out of.
- **Spleet enters Kenya with rent-financing before Vestra:** ship Rent Advance v1 by month 9 in Vestra Credit Ltd wrapper.
- **BuyRentKenya (Rushbox) turns around with fresh capital:** keep momentum on agent BD and content SEO to hold post-acquisition confusion window.

Financial risks.

- **Runway underestimated:** hire schedule can be deferred by 1-2 months; agent BD can compress with commission-heavy pay. Keep 3-month buffer minimum.
- **Escrow float loss:** insured under fidelity guarantee + partner-bank indemnity; audit reconciliation daily.

21. Executable checklist (do in order)

Week 0-2

1. Register company (eCitizen BRS)
2. Corporate KRA PIN + iTax + eTIMS onboarding
3. Register domain (vestra.co.ke + defensively .com/.app/.africa)
4. Open business bank account
5. Retain corporate counsel + fractional DPO
6. File ODPC registration (controller + processor)
7. Trademark filing at KIPI (classes 36 + 42)
8. Draft SHA + ESOP with counsel

Week 2-6

9. Insurance broker meetings — bind PI + cyber + D&O
10. ToS / Privacy / Escrow / Landlord / Tenancy templates drafted
11. DPIA + Records of Processing register
12. Apply for Safaricom Daraja sandbox + production shortcodes
13. Onboard Smile Identity KYC (sandbox integration)
14. Sign up IntaSend + Flutterwave
15. Africa's Talking + CAK Sender ID application
16. First engineering hire started; ship remaining backend criticals + iOS Info.plist

17. Apply Prisma baseline migration to staging DB

Week 6-12

18. Bank BD — HFC + NCBA discovery meetings; issue trust-deed draft

19. Daraja production credentials received; wire STK Push + B2C

20. eRITS Gava Connect sandbox integration + eTIMS invoice generator

21. Ship geofenced photo-verified listing on Capacitor

22. Onboard first 50 verified listings + 10 EARB agents

23. Sentry + Grafana + PostHog + OneSignal live

24. Vitest + supertest regression suite (auth, IDOR, escrow, refresh rotation, verify decide)

25. Beta launch to 100 users (Nairobi)

Month 3-6

26. Sign partner-bank trust deed; escrow rail live

27. KYC gate on all landlord onboarding

28. Landlord SaaS dashboard v1 (rent + MRI + reconciliation)

29. Public launch — Nairobi + Kiambu counties

30. Agent BD: onboard top 30 EARB agents

31. Start seed round conversations

Month 6-12

32. eRITS filing live for landlords

33. Vestimate v0 with 6 months of transaction data

34. Diaspora MVP (US + UK)

35. Form Vestra Credit Ltd (Rent Advance track)

36. Series A conversations start

Prepared 2026-07-04. Costs are indicative ranges based on public 2025-2026 KE market data. Actual figures depend on vendor negotiation and scope. This document is not legal, tax, or financial advice — engage licensed counsel + accountants for final decisions. Sources: [research/01_global_playbooks.md](#), [research/02_competitors.md](#), [research/03_regulatory_fiscal.md](#), [research/04_diaspora.md](#), [research/05_tech_stack.md](#), [VESTRA_STRATEGY_2026.md](#).